

The Sharing Tree

A story about generosity and why sharing brings more happiness than keeping things for yourself

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

For children ages 4-10

[Illustration: Beautiful, colorful cover art depicting the main character]

Dedication

To every child who knows the joy of sharing and to those about to discover it. The more you give, the more you have.

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In the heart of Sunflower Meadow stood the most magnificent tree anyone had ever seen. It was called the Sharing Tree, and for a hundred years it had fed every creature in the meadow.

Its branches hung heavy with the most delicious fruit—golden apples, purple plums, ruby cherries, and honey pears.

Every animal was welcome to eat as much as they needed. And the tree always grew more.

[Illustration: A spectacular, enormous tree loaded with colorful fruit of every kind, animals of all types gathered around eating happily, a magical golden glow surrounding the tree]

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The rabbits came for breakfast. The deer came for lunch. The birds snacked all day long. No one ever went hungry in Sunflower Meadow because the Sharing Tree had enough for everyone.

And here was the magical part: the more fruit the animals took, the more the tree grew. Every fruit that was picked was replaced by two more. Sharing made the tree stronger, not weaker.

[Illustration: Happy animals of various types eating from the tree at different times rabbits, deer, birds, mice the tree visibly growing new fruit wherever some has been taken]

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But then one autumn, a new animal arrived in Sunflower Meadow. His name was Gritch, and he was a very greedy squirrel.

Gritch had come from a place where food was scarce, and he had learned to grab everything he could.

When he saw the Sharing Tree, his eyes went wide with hunger and then narrowed with greed.

'All this fruit!' he whispered. 'If I take it ALL, I'll never be hungry again! I'll be the richest squirrel in the world!'

[Illustration: A sneaky-looking squirrel with greedy narrow eyes arriving at the edge of Sunflower Meadow, staring at the fruit-laden tree with an expression of selfish calculation]

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That very night, while everyone slept, Gritch worked furiously.

He picked every single fruit from the Sharing Tree and stored them in his hollow log.

Apples, plums, cherries, pears he stuffed them all away where no one else could reach them.

Then he built a wall around his log with sticks and thorns. 'MINE!' he declared. 'All mine!'

By morning, the Sharing Tree stood bare not a single fruit remained on its branches.

[Illustration: Gritch frantically stuffing fruit into his hollow log in the moonlight, the tree being stripped bare, a wall of thorns being built around his stash, greedy and secretive]

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When the animals woke and came for breakfast, they found nothing. Just empty branches reaching toward the sky.

'Where's the fruit?' the young rabbit cried, his tummy growling.

The old deer looked worried. 'In all my years, the tree has never been empty.'

Then they noticed Gritch sitting on his thorn-wall, cheeks puffed with fruit. 'What are you all staring at? Get your own food!'

The animals looked at each other in confusion. Get their OWN food? The tree had always shared.

[Illustration: The bare tree with empty branches, confused and hungry animals gathered beneath it, Gritch visible on his pile of hoarded fruit behind thorns, eating selfishly while others go hungry]

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Something terrible began to happen to the Sharing Tree.

Without animals eating its fruit and spreading its seeds, the tree started to wilt.

Its leaves turned yellow, then brown. Its branches drooped. Its bark turned gray and dry.

The Sharing Tree was dying. Not from having too much taken but from having NOTHING shared.

The tree needed to give. That was its magic. That was its life. And Gritch had stopped the giving.

[Illustration: The once-magnificent tree now wilting, leaves turning brown, branches drooping sadly, bark cracking, a sick and dying tree compared to its former glory]

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Meanwhile, Gritch sat in his log surrounded by mountains of fruit. More than he could ever eat.

But a strange thing happened the fruit was rotting. Faster than normal.

The apples turned brown and mushy. The pears went soft and smelly. The plums grew fuzzy mold.

Gritch tried eating faster, but he couldn't keep up with the rot. Food meant for sharing spoils when hoarded.

'No! My precious fruit!' Gritch wailed, watching his treasure turn to mush.

[Illustration: Gritch inside his log surrounded by rotting, moldy fruit, looking panicked as his hoarded treasure decays around him, a disgusting mess of spoiled food]

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Outside, the meadow was growing sad and quiet. Animals were hungry and leaving to find food elsewhere.

The birds flew away. The deer moved to distant forests. The rabbits dug deeper into their burrows.

Sunflower Meadow, once full of life and laughter, was becoming empty and silent.

Even the sunflowers drooped their golden heads, missing the cheerful energy that used to fill the air.

[Illustration: A desolate Sunflower Meadow with animals leaving birds flying away, deer walking into the distance, empty rabbit holes the once-vibrant meadow now quiet and lonely]

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A young mouse named Pip (the bravest in the meadow) went to talk to Gritch.

'Gritch, please share the fruit. The tree is dying. The meadow is empty. Everyone is hungry.'

'NOT MY PROBLEM!' Gritch snapped. 'I need to protect what's MINE!'

'But it's all rotting,' Pip pointed out. 'You can't eat it all. It's going to waste. If you shared, there would be enough for everyone including you.'

Gritch slammed his thorn-door shut. 'Go away!'

[Illustration: Tiny brave mouse Pip standing outside Gritch's thorn wall, trying to reason with the angry squirrel who peers through a gap with hostile eyes, rotting fruit visible behind him]

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Days passed. The Sharing Tree was nearly dead now just a skeleton of branches against the gray sky.

And Gritch? Gritch was miserable. All his fruit was rotten. He was actually hungry now too.

Worse than hunger, though, was the loneliness. There were no other animals to talk to. No one to play with. No sounds of life.

He had everything he'd wanted all the fruit to himself and he'd never been more unhappy.

'What's the point of having everything if you're all alone?' he whispered to his empty meadow.

[Illustration: Gritch sitting alone outside his log, surrounded by rotten fruit, looking at the empty quiet meadow with a devastated expression, the dead tree in the background, complete loneliness]

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That night, Gritch had a dream. In the dream, the Sharing Tree spoke to him.

'I was happiest when I was giving,' the tree said in a creaky, ancient voice. 'That is my nature. To share.'

'But you kept everything, and now look at us both I am dying, your fruit is rotten, and the meadow is empty.'

'Is this what you wanted? To have everything and enjoy nothing?'

Gritch woke up with tears in his eyes. 'No,' he whispered. 'This isn't what I wanted at all.'

[Illustration: A dream sequence with a ghostly image of the Sharing Tree speaking to Gritch, its trunk forming a wise ancient face, Gritch looking small and ashamed before it]

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The next morning, Gritch did something that surprised everyone especially himself. He tore down his thorn wall. He dragged out all the remaining fruit (what hadn't rotted) and piled it beneath the dying tree.

Then he dug the seeds from the rotted fruit and planted them in the earth around the tree's roots.

'I'm sorry,' he said to the tree, to the meadow, to the empty sky. 'I'm sorry I took everything. I'm sorry I was greedy.'

'I don't want to be alone anymore. I want the meadow to be alive again.'

[Illustration: Gritch tearfully tearing down his thorn walls, carrying fruit to the base of the dying tree, planting seeds in the ground, apologizing with genuine remorse]

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The moment Gritch gave back what he'd taken, something magical happened.

The Sharing Tree shuddered. Its dry bark softened. A single green leaf sprouted from a bare branch.

Then another. And another. Slowly, beautifully, the tree began to come back to life.

The seeds Gritch planted began to sprout around the base. Tiny saplings pushed up through the earth.

Generosity was flowing again, and the tree could feel it.

[Illustration: The Sharing Tree beginning to revive new green leaves sprouting on bare branches, tiny saplings growing around its base, a miraculous rebirth, Gritch watching in amazement]

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Pip the mouse saw the change and raced to tell the other animals. 'Come back! The tree is growing again!'

Slowly, cautiously, the animals returned. The birds flew back. The deer emerged from the forest. The rabbits hopped out of their burrows.

When they saw Gritch sitting beneath the recovering tree with no walls around him, they were confused.

'I'm sorry,' Gritch said to each one. 'I took what belonged to all of us. I was wrong. Please come back.'

[Illustration: Animals cautiously returning to the meadow birds landing in branches, deer approaching, rabbits hopping back Gritch with no walls looking humble and apologetic]

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The animals were wary at first. Could they trust Gritch?

But the tree was growing back, and Gritch was helping watering the saplings, clearing the dead leaves, making space for others to sit in the shade.

Day by day, he proved with his actions that he had changed. He took only what he needed and helped others get theirs.

Trust, like the tree, grew back slowly. But it grew back.

[Illustration: Gritch helping tend the tree watering saplings, sweeping up dead leaves while other animals watch, gradually moving closer, trust slowly rebuilding]

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Within weeks, the Sharing Tree was more magnificent than ever.

Its branches spread wide and welcoming, heavy with twice as much fruit as before.

The saplings Gritch had planted grew into a whole grove of young sharing trees.

Instead of one tree feeding the meadow, now there were MANY enough fruit for every creature, with plenty left over.

Gritch's mistake had actually led to something wonderful: MORE sharing, not less.

[Illustration: The restored Sharing Tree now surrounded by young saplings growing into a grove, even more fruit than before, the meadow flourishing, animals happily eating from multiple trees]

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And Gritch? Gritch became the most generous animal in the meadow.

He'd learned the hard way what greed does – it rots your treasure, kills what feeds you, and drives everyone away.

Now he was always the first to help others find the ripest fruit, the first to share his acorns in winter, the first to welcome new animals to the meadow.

'Aren't you afraid of running out?' a young squirrel once asked him.

'No,' Gritch smiled. 'I learned something important: sharing never makes less. It always makes more.'

[Illustration: Gritch happily helping other animals reach fruit, sharing generously with a young squirrel, looking content and peaceful, a completely transformed character]

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One cold winter, a family of rabbits arrived in the meadow with nothing no food stored, no warm burrow prepared.

The old Gritch would have ignored them. But the new Gritch immediately shared his acorn stash.

'Take what you need!' he said, opening his stores. 'There is plenty for everyone.'

Other animals joined in bringing bedding, extra food, warm moss. The rabbit family was safe within hours.

'This is how a community works,' Gritch told the young squirrel watching. 'When we ALL share, nobody goes without.'

[Illustration: Gritch opening his acorn store to a cold rabbit family, other animals bringing supplies too, a warm community coming together in winter, generosity in action]

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Spring came, and the rabbit family planted a whole new section of wildflowers in the meadow as thanks.

'You shared with us when we had nothing,' they said. 'So we want to add beauty to this place for everyone.'

Gritch smiled. That was how it always worked now every gift given came back multiplied. Not because the animals were keeping score, but because generosity creates a cycle of giving that never ends.

The meadow had become a place where everyone looked out for everyone else.

[Illustration: The rabbit family planting colorful wildflowers in the meadow as a thank-you, Gritch watching happily, the cycle of generosity continuing, spring flowers blooming everywhere]

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Pip the mouse became Gritch's best friend she had been the one brave enough to talk to him when no one else would.

'You know what I admire most about you?' Pip told Gritch one evening. 'You did not just stop being greedy. You became the most generous animal I know.'

'I had to make up for lost time,' Gritch laughed. 'And honestly? Giving things away feels SO much better than hoarding them.'

'It is like my heart has more room now. When I was grabbing everything, my heart was cramped. Now that I give freely, it feels enormous.'

[Illustration: Gritch and tiny Pip sitting together at sunset, good friends now, both content, the magnificent grove of sharing trees behind them, a beautiful friendship]

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The Sharing Tree lived for another hundred years, and the grove grew even bigger. A plaque was placed at its base that read: 'This tree thrives on generosity. Take what you need. Share what you can. And there will always be enough for everyone.'
And it was true. When everyone shared, there was always plenty. Always. Because that's the beautiful secret about generosity: it multiplies what you have. Hoarding divides it.

[Illustration: The magnificent grove of sharing trees with a beautiful plaque at the base of the original tree, all the meadow animals living in abundance and harmony]

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So here's what the Sharing Tree teaches us:

When you share your toys, your snacks, your time, your kindness it doesn't leave you with less.

It actually gives you MORE: more friends, more happiness, more love coming back to you.

But when you hoard and keep everything for yourself, it spoils. Like Gritch's fruit. It rots when it's not shared.

Be generous. Share freely. And watch your world grow into a beautiful grove of goodness.

[Illustration: A child sharing toys with friends, snacks with siblings, time with someone lonely showing that sharing in real life creates abundance and joy, warm and inviting final image]

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Here is a challenge from the Sharing Tree, just for you:

This week, try sharing something every single day. It does not have to be big.

Monday: share a smile with someone who looks sad. Tuesday: share your time by helping with a chore. Wednesday: share a compliment tell someone what you like about them.

Thursday: share your food give a friend half your cookie. Friday: share your things lend a toy or a book.

Watch what happens. Watch how sharing makes YOU feel. Watch how it makes others feel.

Watch how the garden grows.

[Illustration: A weekly calendar showing different sharing acts for each day, drawn like a child's colorful planner, with small flowers growing beside each completed sharing act]

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And always remember: the Sharing Tree's greatest lesson was not just about fruit.

It was about this: things that are hoarded die. Things that are shared multiply.

Love shared becomes more love. Joy shared becomes more joy. Kindness shared becomes more kindness.

You are a Sharing Tree too. Everything you give away comes back to you doubled.

So share without fear. Give without counting. And grow without limits.

[Illustration: A child standing with arms outstretched like tree branches, friends and family gathered around like animals around the Sharing Tree, love and kindness flowing outward and returning multiplied]

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And so the story of the Sharing Tree goes on forever because sharing never ends.
Every time a child shares a toy, the tree grows a new branch. Every time someone gives a hug, a flower blooms on that branch.

Every time a family shares a meal, the roots grow deeper and stronger.

The Sharing Tree lives in all of us. And as long as one person somewhere is generous, it will never, ever die.

Be that person today. Be the one who keeps the tree alive. Share something. Anything. And watch the magic grow.

[Illustration: The magnificent Sharing Tree alive and growing across generations, children of all ages contributing to its growth through acts of sharing, timeless and eternal, a never-ending story]

The Moral of the Story

Generosity Brings More Happiness Than Keeping Things for Yourself

The Sharing Tree showed us that keeping everything for yourself doesn't make you happier it makes you lonely and your treasures rot. But sharing? Sharing makes everything grow. When you give generously, you get back more than you gave in friendship, in love, in the joy of making others happy. So share your toys, share your snacks, share your time, share your smile. You'll never run out of good things when your heart is generous.

Discussion Questions for Parents

After reading this story together, talk about these questions:

1. Have you ever NOT wanted to share something? What happened? How did you feel?
2. Why do you think the fruit rotted when Gritch hoarded it, but stayed fresh on the Sharing Tree?
3. Can you think of something you could share this week that would make someone else happy?
4. What's the difference between sharing because you want to and sharing because someone made you?
5. If you were an animal in Sunflower Meadow, would you have forgiven Gritch? Why or why not?

About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a storyteller who believes every child deserves stories that spark imagination, build character, and fill hearts with wonder.

His stories are crafted to help children understand important life lessons through adventure, friendship, and the magic of imagination.

When not writing, Daniel enjoys spending time with family, exploring nature, and dreaming up new worlds for young readers to discover.

Thank you for reading! If your child enjoyed this story, please look for other books in the collection.